

New Engineer Onboarding Checklist

wiki/people/onboarding-checklist · Updated 2026-07-05 · Owner: People, Platform

Welcome

This checklist walks a new engineer through their first two weeks at Northwind. It is maintained by the People and Platform teams. Your onboarding buddy will help you work through it; ask questions early and often in the #eng-help channel.

The aim of onboarding is simple: by the end of week two you should have shipped a small change to production and understand how we build, review, and release software.

Before day one

Your manager and IT arrange your accounts and equipment before you start. If something is not ready on day one, that is normal; open a ticket and your buddy will help you chase it. Do not worry about being productive immediately. The first week is about setup and context.

Week 1: setup and access

- Get your laptop imaged by IT and enable disk encryption.
- Enable single sign-on and register your second factor.
- Request access to the engineering GitHub organisation.

- Read the architecture overview and the engineering handbook.
- Set up your local development environment and build a service end to end.
- Join the core team channels and introduce yourself.
- Set up the VPN so you can reach internal systems.

Meet your team

Spend time in week one meeting the people you will work with. Schedule short introductions with your manager, your onboarding buddy, and the leads of the teams your service depends on. Ask them what they wish they had known in their first month.

Learn the landscape

Read the top-level architecture overview and skim the runbooks for the services your team owns. You are not expected to remember it all; the goal is to know where to look.

Week 2: your first change

- Pick up a starter task labelled good-first-issue.
- Pair with your onboarding buddy on the change.
- Open a pull request and go through code review.
- Deploy a small change end to end following the CI/CD pipeline.
- Write a short note about anything in the docs that was confusing or wrong.

Learning the release process

Shadow a teammate through a real release so you understand how changes reach production. Read the CI/CD standards and the on-call runbook so you know what happens after you merge. Your first deploy should be a small, low-risk change with your buddy watching.

Your first code review

Expect feedback on your first pull request; that is the point. Review is a conversation, not a judgement. Respond to comments, ask questions when something is unclear, and treat it as the fastest way to learn how we work.

Tools and accounts

By the end of onboarding you should have working access to source control, the CI/CD pipeline, observability dashboards, the internal wiki, and the communication channels your team uses. If anything is missing, open a ticket with IT.

Culture and expectations

- Ask questions; nobody expects you to know everything in week one.
- Prefer small, reviewable changes over large ones.
- Write things down so the next new hire has an easier time.
- Flag anything unclear so we can keep the documentation healthy.
- Default to sharing context in the open so others can follow along.

Worked example

A new engineer spends week one getting their laptop set up, enabling single sign-on, joining channels, and reading the architecture overview. In week two they pick up a good-first-issue, pair with their buddy, open a pull request, respond to review feedback, and deploy the change through the pipeline with their buddy watching. They finish by noting two confusing steps in the setup docs so the next hire has it easier.

Frequently asked questions

I do not have access to something I need. Open a ticket with IT and ask your buddy to help you follow up.

How quickly should I be productive? The first two weeks are about setup and context. A small shipped change by the end of week two is a great outcome.

Who do I ask for help? Your onboarding buddy first, then your team, then #eng-help.

Common mistakes

- Trying to take on a large task before understanding the release process.
- Staying stuck in silence instead of asking in #eng-help.
- Skipping the architecture reading and getting lost later.
- Not writing down the rough edges you hit, so the next hire hits them too.

Getting help

If you are blocked, ask in #eng-help before spending more than thirty minutes stuck. Your buddy and your manager are there to unblock you, and asking early is a sign of good judgement, not weakness.

Related documents

See the Deployment Guide and CI/CD Pipeline Standards for how changes ship, the VPN Access guide for remote access, and the Remote Work Policy for working arrangements.

Your first 90 days

Onboarding does not end after two weeks. The first ninety days are about going from your first small change to being a confident, independent contributor to your team.

- By day 30: you are shipping small changes regularly and know who owns what.
- By day 60: you are picking up normal team work and reviewing others' changes.
- By day 90: you are contributing to design discussions and can take an incident shift with support.

Check in with your manager at each milestone. If anything is blocking your progress, surface it early; onboarding is a shared responsibility, and feedback about rough edges helps the next hire too.

Working with your buddy

Your onboarding buddy is your first point of contact for the small questions that are faster to ask than to search for. Use them, and do not worry about asking too much in the early weeks.

- Set up a regular short check-in for your first few weeks.
- Keep a running list of questions so you can batch the small ones.
- Ask your buddy to walk you through a real change and a real incident response.
- Pass on what you learn by improving the docs for the next person.

A good buddy relationship shortens the time to your first confident contribution and makes the whole team more welcoming.